

Westminster Standards Harmonized

(Modern English) - Without Scripture Proofs

These following sections contain harmonized modern-English summaries from the Westminster Confession of Faith, Shorter Catechism, and Larger Catechism.

“For the glory of God and the equipping of His saints by the
Ezra 7:10

Learn, Do, Teach method.”

THEOLOGY – THE DOCTRINE OF GOD

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THEOLOGY – The Doctrine of God

The Godhead of the Holy Spirit

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 2.3; 1.5; 8.8; 13.1 The Holy Spirit is the third person of the Trinity—fully and eternally God, of one substance, equal in power and glory with the Father and the Son. He eternally proceeds from the Father and the Son and shares in all the works of the Godhead. It is the Spirit who inspired the prophets and apostles to write the Scriptures, who illuminates the hearts of believers to recognize the truth, and who applies the redemption accomplished by Christ. He gives new life, produces holiness, strengthens faith, and equips the church for service. The Spirit works sovereignly, revealing and glorifying Christ, and bringing God’s purposes to completion in the hearts of His people and throughout creation.	WSC 29–30; 6 Q. 29 - <i>How are we made partakers of the redemption purchased by Christ?</i> A. We are made partakers of the redemption by the effectual application of it to us by His Holy Spirit. Q. 30 - <i>How does the Spirit apply the redemption purchased by Christ?</i> A. The Spirit applies it to us by working faith in our hearts and uniting us to Christ in our effectual calling. (From Q.6) - <i>The Holy Spirit is one of the three persons of the one God, the same in substance, equal in power and glory.</i>	WLC 32, 58, 75; 9–11 Q. 32 - <i>How is the grace of God made effective in the elect?</i> A. The Spirit of God applies to them the redemption purchased by Christ by working faith and renewing their wills, persuading and enabling them to embrace Christ freely. Q. 58 - <i>How do we come to be made partakers of the benefits which Christ has procured?</i> A. By the Spirit’s effectual application of Christ’s work through the covenant of grace. Q. 75 <i>What is sanctification?</i> A. Sanctification is the work of God’s free grace by which His Spirit renews the whole person after the image of God and enables believers more and more to die to sin and live to righteousness. (From Q.9–11) <i>The Holy Spirit is eternally proceeding from the Father and the Son, equal with them in substance, power, and glory.</i>

THEOLOGY – The Doctrine of God

The Decrees of God

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 3.1–3.3 From all eternity, according to His own wise and holy will, God freely and unchangeably decreed everything that happens. Yet He does so in such a way that He is neither the author of sin nor does He violate the will or responsibility of His creatures. Instead, His sovereign purposes include even the free and contingent actions of people and events. God’s decrees reveal His infinite wisdom, power, and goodness. All that He ordains will certainly come to pass, for He works all things according to the counsel of His own will and for His own glory.	WSC 7 Q. 7 - <i>What are the decrees of God?</i> A. The decrees of God are His eternal purpose, according to the counsel of His will, by which, for His own glory, He has foreordained whatsoever comes to pass.	WLC 12–14 Q. 12 - <i>What are the decrees of God?</i> A. God’s decrees are the wise, free, and holy acts of His will, by which He has eternally and unchangeably ordained whatever comes to pass, particularly concerning angels and men. Q. 13 - <i>What has God especially decreed concerning angels and men?</i> A. By His eternal decree, some angels and men are chosen to everlasting life through Christ, and others are permitted to fall and remain in sin, to the praise of His glorious justice. Q. 14 - <i>How does God carry out His decrees?</i> A. God carries out His decrees in the works of creation and providence, which flow perfectly from His eternal purpose.

THEOLOGY – The Doctrine of God

Predestination

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 3.4–3.8 By the decree of God, for the manifestation of His glory, some men and angels are predestined to eternal life and others foreordained to everlasting death. These numbers are fixed and certain, determined before the foundation of the world according to His eternal and unchangeable purpose, and based solely on His free grace and good pleasure—not because of anything foreseen in the creature. Those chosen in Christ are effectually called, justified, adopted, sanctified, and kept by His power through faith to salvation. The rest are passed over in their sin and left to the just judgment of God for their rebellion, to the praise of His glorious justice. This doctrine should move believers to humility, diligence, and praise rather than pride or despair.	WSC 20 Q. 20 - <i>Did God leave all mankind to perish in the estate of sin and misery?</i> A. God, out of His mere good pleasure, from all eternity, chose some to everlasting life and entered into a covenant of grace to deliver them out of the estate of sin and misery and to bring them to salvation by a Redeemer.	WLC 13, 67–69 Q. 13 - <i>What has God especially decreed concerning angels and men?</i> A. He has chosen some to eternal life and others to dishonor and wrath for their sin. Q. 67 <i>What is effectual calling?</i> A. It is the work of God's almighty power and grace by which He draws the elect to Himself through His Word and Spirit, enlightening their minds and renewing their wills to embrace the grace offered in the gospel. Q. 68–69 - <i>Why are not all called effectually?</i> A. Because only those whom God has predestined to life receive the Spirit's inward call, and the rest, though outwardly called, remain in their sin and unbelief.

THEOLOGY – The Doctrine of God

Creation

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 4.1 It pleased God the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, for the manifestation of His eternal power, wisdom, and goodness, to create the world and everything in it out of nothing, in the space of six days, and all very good. This act of creation was entirely free, arising from God's sovereign will. Nothing existed before Him or apart from His purpose. The entire universe—visible and invisible, material and spiritual—owes its being to Him alone. Creation reveals His glory and wisdom, showing His majesty in the order, beauty, and harmony of all things.	WSC 9 Q. 9 <i>What is the work of creation?</i> A. The work of creation is God's making all things from nothing, by the word of His power, in the space of six days, and all very good.	WLC 15–17 Q. 15 <i>What is the work of creation?</i> A. The work of creation is that act of the triune God by which, in the beginning, for His own glory, He made the world and everything in it from nothing, in six days, and all very good. Q. 16 <i>How did God create angels?</i> A. God created all angels as spirits, immortal, holy, mighty, and to serve Him—but capable of falling. Q. 17 <i>How did God create man?</i> A. God created man, male and female, after His own image, in knowledge, righteousness, and holiness, with dominion over the creatures. <i>(Reserved for Anthropology)</i>

THEOLOGY – The Doctrine of God

Providence

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 5.1–5.7 God, the great Creator of all things, upholds, directs, governs, and orders everything that happens in the universe—both great and small—by His wise and holy providence, according to His infallible foreknowledge and the counsel of His own will, for the praise of His glory. God’s providence extends to all creatures and all actions. Nothing occurs by chance. Yet His rule does not remove the freedom or responsibility of His creatures, but rather establishes them. In His ordinary providence, God uses means—laws of nature, human decisions, and secondary causes—but He is free to work without, above, or against them as He pleases. God’s providence shows His justice, wisdom, and goodness: allowing sin to occur for His purposes, restraining it, ordering it for good, and using it to reveal His glory in both mercy and judgment. To His church, He reveals His fatherly care—disciplining, comforting, and guiding His people for their growth and His praise.	WSC 11 Q. 11 <i>What are God’s works of providence?</i> A. God’s works of providence are His most holy, wise, and powerful preserving and governing of all His creatures and all their actions.	WLC 18–20 Q. 18 <i>What are God’s works of providence?</i> A. God’s works of providence are His most holy, wise, and powerful preserving and governing of all His creatures and all their actions, ordering them for His own glory. Q. 19 <i>What is God’s providence toward angels?</i> A. God kept some angels from falling by confirming them in holiness and happiness, while others He permitted to fall and be eternally punished. Q. 20 <i>What is God’s providence toward man in the state in which he was created?</i> A. God placed man in the Garden, entered into covenant with him, and gave him freedom and ability to obey, promising life upon obedience and death upon disobedience.

ANTHROPOLOGY – The Doctrine of Man

The Creation of Man

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 4.2 After God had made all other creatures, He created man, male and female, with living, reasonable, and immortal souls. They were made in the image of God—in knowledge, righteousness, and holiness—and given dominion over the creatures. God wrote His moral law upon their hearts and gave them the ability to obey it perfectly. Yet they were free to disobey, being left to the liberty of their own will, which was subject to change. They were also given communion with God, and the Sabbath, and placed under a covenant of life on condition of perfect obedience.	WSC 10 Q. 10 <i>How did God create man?</i> A. God created man, male and female, after His own image, in knowledge, righteousness, and holiness, with dominion over the creatures.	WLC 17, 20 Q. 17 <i>How did God create man?</i> A. God created man, male and female, after His own image, in knowledge, righteousness, and holiness, having the law of God written in their hearts and the power to fulfill it, yet with freedom to fall. Q. 20 <i>What was God's providence toward man in the state in which he was created?</i> A. God entered into a covenant of life with man upon condition of perfect obedience, forbidding him to eat of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil on penalty of death.

ANTHROPOLOGY – The Doctrine of Man

The Fall of Man, Original Sin, and Punishment

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 6.1–6.6 Our first parents, Adam and Eve, though created upright and free, sinned against God by eating the forbidden fruit. This sin was not merely an external act—it was rebellion against God’s authority and goodness, violating His command and seeking independence from Him. By this fall, they lost their original righteousness and communion with God, and became dead in sin and wholly defiled in every part of their being. The guilt of this sin was imputed, and the corrupted nature conveyed, to all their descendants by ordinary generation. From this corruption, all actual sins proceed. Humanity is now unable, apart from divine grace, to return to God or do anything truly good. This spiritual death deserves God’s wrath and curse, both in this life and the next. Yet even in judgment, God’s purpose of redemption was already being revealed.	WSC 13–19 Q. 13 <i>Did our first parents continue in the state in which they were created?</i> A. Our first parents, being left to the freedom of their own will, fell from the state in which they were created by sinning against God. Q. 14 <i>What is sin?</i> A. Sin is any lack of conformity to, or transgression of, the law of God. Q. 15 <i>What was the sin whereby our first parents fell from the estate wherein they were created?</i> A. Eating the forbidden fruit. Q. 16 <i>Did all mankind fall in Adam’s first transgression?</i> A. Yes. The covenant being made with Adam as a representative for all, all mankind sinned in him and fell with him in his first transgression. Q. 17 <i>What is the misery of that fall?</i> A. The fall brought all mankind into sin and misery.	WLC 21–29 Q. 21 <i>What was the providence of God toward man in the estate in which he was created?</i> A. God tested man with the command not to eat of the tree of knowledge of good and evil. Q. 22 <i>Did all mankind fall in that first transgression?</i> A. The covenant being made with Adam as a public representative, all his posterity descending from him by ordinary generation sinned in him and fell with him in that first transgression. Q. 23–26 <i>Wherein did the fall consist and what were its consequences?</i> A. By his sin, man lost communion with God, became subject to His wrath, and corrupted in all faculties of soul and body. This corruption is transmitted to all his descendants and produces every actual sin. Q. 27–29 <i>What is the punishment of sin?</i> A. The punishment is alienation from God, His wrath and curse, temporal miseries, death itself, and the pains of hell forever.

	Q. 18–19 - <i>What is the sinfulness of that fallen state, and what misery does it bring?</i> A. We are guilty of Adam’s first sin, lack all original righteousness, are inclined to evil, and experience God’s wrath and curse—both in this life and forever.	
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ANTHROPOLOGY – The Doctrine of Man

God's Covenant with Man

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 7.1–7.6; 8.1 The distance between God and man is so great that, though rational creatures owe obedience to their Creator, they could never attain the blessing of life except by God's voluntary condescension—His gracious entering into covenant with them. The first covenant made with man was a Covenant of Works, in which life was promised to Adam and his descendants upon the condition of perfect and personal obedience. When Adam broke this covenant, all humanity fell with him. God was pleased then to make a Covenant of Grace, wherein He freely offers sinners life and salvation through Jesus Christ, requiring faith in Him for salvation and promising His Holy Spirit to enable them to believe. This covenant was progressively revealed through promises, sacrifices, laws, and ordinances, and is fully accomplished in Christ, the Mediator, who as the eternal Son of God became man to reconcile the elect to God.	WSC 12, 20 Q. 12 <i>What special act of providence did God exercise toward man in the state wherein he was created?</i> A. When God had created man, He entered into a covenant of life with him upon condition of perfect obedience, forbidding him to eat of the tree of knowledge of good and evil on pain of death. Q. 20 <i>Did God leave all mankind to perish in the estate of sin and misery?</i> A. God, out of His mere good pleasure, from all eternity chose some to everlasting life and entered into a covenant of grace to deliver them out of the estate of sin and misery and to bring them to salvation by a Redeemer.	WLC 30–36 Q. 30 - <i>Does God leave all mankind to perish in the state of sin and misery?</i> A. God does not leave all men to perish, but, out of His mere love and mercy, delivers His elect out of it and brings them into a state of salvation by the Covenant of Grace. Q. 31 - <i>With whom was the Covenant of Grace made?</i> A. The Covenant of Grace was made with Christ as the second Adam, and in Him with all the elect as His seed. Q. 32–36 - <i>How is the Covenant of Grace revealed and administered?</i> A. It was revealed in the gospel; first to Adam in the promise of the seed of the woman, and afterward by further steps—through promises, sacrifices, the Passover, and other ordinances—all foreshadowing Christ to come. In the fullness of time, Christ was revealed, and under the new covenant the means of grace are more clearly and powerfully administered in Word and sacrament.

ANTHROPOLOGY – The Doctrine of Man

Free Will and Inability

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 9.1–9.5 God has endued the will of man with natural freedom—it is neither forced nor determined by any absolute necessity of nature to do good or evil. In his state of innocence, man had the freedom and power to will and to do that which was good and pleasing to God, yet was unstable and capable of falling from it. After the fall, man lost all ability to will any spiritual good accompanying salvation. As a natural man, he is dead in sin and unable to convert himself or prepare himself for it. When God converts a sinner and brings him into the state of grace, He frees him from the bondage of sin and, by His grace alone, enables him freely to will and to do that which is spiritually good. Yet because of remaining corruption, he does not perfectly or only desire what is good. In the state of glory, the will of man is made perfectly and immutably free to do good alone.	WSC 82 Q. 82 <i>Is any man able perfectly to keep the commandments of God?</i> A. No mere man, since the fall, is able in this life perfectly to keep the commandments of God, but daily breaks them in thought, word, and deed.	WLC 25, 149 Q. 25 - <i>Wherein consists the sinfulness of that estate into which man fell?</i> A. The sinfulness of that estate consists in the guilt of Adam's first sin, the lack of original righteousness, and the corruption of his whole nature, which renders him utterly indisposed, disabled, and opposed to all that is spiritually good, and wholly inclined to all evil. Q. 149 - <i>Is any man able perfectly to keep the commandments of God?</i> A. No man is able, either of himself or by any grace received in this life, to keep the commandments of God perfectly, but daily breaks them in thought, word, and deed.

CHRISTOLOGY – The Doctrine of Christ

The Need for a Mediator

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 8.1 (introductory logic) Because man, by his fall, made himself incapable of life through the Covenant of Works, it pleased God to provide another covenant—one of grace—wherein He freely offers salvation through a Mediator. This Mediator must be truly God and truly man, perfectly righteous, to reconcile sinners to God, bear His wrath, and bring them into fellowship with Him. No mere creature could satisfy divine justice or renew human nature; therefore, only the eternal Son of God could fulfill this office.	WSC 20–21 Q. 20 - <i>Did God leave all mankind to perish in the estate of sin and misery?</i> A. God, out of His mere good pleasure, chose some to everlasting life and entered into a covenant of grace to deliver them by a Redeemer. Q. 21 - <i>Who is the Redeemer of God's elect?</i> A. The only Redeemer is the Lord Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, who became man and so is both God and man in two distinct natures and one person forever.	WLC 29–36 Q. 29 - <i>What is the misery of that estate whereinto man fell?</i> A. All mankind, by their fall, lost communion with God, incurred His wrath and curse, and so became dead in sin and wholly defiled. Q. 30 - <i>Does God leave all mankind to perish in that estate?</i> A. No. Out of His mere love and mercy, He delivers His elect by a Redeemer. Q. 36 - <i>Who is the Mediator of the covenant of grace?</i> A. The only Mediator is the Lord Jesus Christ, who, being the eternal Son of God, became man and continues to be both God and man in two distinct natures and one person forever.

CHRISTOLOGY – The Doctrine of Christ

Christ the Mediator

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 8.1–8.8 It pleased God, in His eternal purpose, to choose and ordain the Lord Jesus Christ, His only begotten Son, to be the Mediator between God and man—the Prophet, Priest, and King, the Head and Savior of His Church, the Heir of all things, and Judge of the world. To fulfill this office, the Son of God took upon Himself our nature, yet without sin. He was conceived by the power of the Holy Spirit in the womb of the virgin Mary, and united two whole, perfect natures—divine and human—in one person forever. As Mediator, Christ perfectly obeyed the law, offered Himself once as a sacrifice to satisfy divine justice, and reconciled His people to God. He rose from the dead, ascended into heaven, and sits at the right hand of the Father, making continual intercession for believers and governing all things for their good. All that Christ accomplished was by divine appointment and power; yet He willingly fulfilled every part of His mediatorial work in love and obedience to His Father.	WSC 21, 23–28 Q. 21 <i>Who is the Redeemer of God’s elect?</i> A. The only Redeemer is the Lord Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, who became man, and so is both God and man in two distinct natures and one person forever. Q. 23 <i>What offices does Christ execute as our Redeemer?</i> A. Christ executes the offices of a Prophet, of a Priest, and of a King, both in His humiliation and exaltation. Q. 24–28 <i>How does He fulfill these offices?</i> A. As Prophet, He reveals God’s will for our salvation; as Priest, He offered Himself once as a sacrifice to satisfy divine justice and intercedes for us; and as King, He subdues us to Himself, rules and defends us, and restrains and conquers all His and our enemies.	WLC 36–56 Q. 36 <i>Who is the Mediator of the covenant of grace?</i> A. The only Mediator is the Lord Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, who became man and continues to be both God and man in two distinct natures and one person forever. Q. 37–39 <i>How did Christ become man, and why?</i> A. He took on human nature, conceived by the Holy Spirit in the womb of the virgin Mary, so that two perfect natures—divine and human—were joined together in one person, to be our Mediator and Redeemer. Q. 40–56 <i>How does Christ execute His offices as Prophet, Priest, and King?</i> A. As Prophet, He reveals by His Word and Spirit the will of God for our salvation. As Priest, He offered Himself once for all as a sacrifice, intercedes continually, and makes our persons and services acceptable to God. As King, He calls His people out of the world to Himself, gives them officers, laws, and discipline, protects them, rewards obedience, corrects sin, and subdues His and our enemies.

CHRISTOLOGY – The Doctrine of Christ

The Names of Christ

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 8.1; 8.8; 2.3 The Lord Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, is called by many names which declare His person and office. He is the Word, through whom all things were made; the Son of God, of one substance and glory with the Father; the Christ, anointed with the Spirit to fulfill the roles of Prophet, Priest, and King; the Lord, to whom every knee shall bow; the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world; and Immanuel, meaning “God with us.” Each of these names reveals an aspect of His eternal identity and mediatorial work: the Word who reveals God, the Son who is beloved of the Father, the Christ who saves His people, and the Lord who reigns forever. Through all these titles, the confession unites His deity and humanity in one person — Jesus, the Christ, our Savior and Judge.	WSC 21, 23 Q. 21 <i>Who is the Redeemer of God’s elect?</i> A. The only Redeemer is the Lord Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, who became man, and so is both God and man in two distinct natures and one person forever. Q. 23 <i>What offices does Christ execute as our Redeemer?</i> A. Christ, the Anointed One, executes the offices of Prophet, Priest, and King, both in His humiliation and exaltation. (“Christ” meaning “Anointed One,” reveals Him as the Spirit-endowed Savior of God’s people.)	WLC 36, 42, 45–46, 55–56 Q. 36 <i>Who is the Mediator of the covenant of grace?</i> A. The Lord Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, who became man, continues to be both God and man forever. Q. 42 <i>Why is our Mediator called Christ?</i> A. Because He was anointed with the Holy Spirit beyond measure, being set apart and fully equipped by the Father to perform the offices of Prophet, Priest, and King. Q. 45–46 - <i>Why is He called the Son of God and the Son of Man?</i> A. He is the Son of God by eternal generation from the Father, and Son of Man because He took on our nature. These titles show His full deity and true humanity united in one person. Q. 55–56 <i>Why is He called Lord and Savior?</i> A. Because He has redeemed us by His blood and now reigns with authority over all creation and over His redeemed people forever.

CHRISTOLOGY – The Doctrine of Christ

The Natures of Jesus Christ

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 8.2–8.7 The Son of God, the second person of the Trinity, is truly and eternally God—of one substance, equal in power and glory with the Father. When the fullness of time came, He took on a true human nature, with all its essential properties and common weaknesses, yet without sin. By the power of the Holy Spirit, He was conceived in the womb of the virgin Mary, uniting in Himself two whole, perfect, and distinct natures—divine and human—into one person forever. Thus, the Lord Jesus Christ is one person with two natures: fully God and fully man. His divine and human natures remain distinct, yet inseparably joined, so that what belongs to one nature is rightly attributed to the single person. This mystery of the incarnation was necessary that the Mediator might be able to suffer and intercede for us as man, and also to bear infinite wrath and conquer death as God.	WSC 21, 27 Q. 21 <i>Who is the Redeemer of God's elect?</i> A. The only Redeemer is the Lord Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, who became man, and so is both God and man in two distinct natures and one person forever. Q. 27 <i>Wherein did Christ's humiliation consist?</i> A. Christ's humiliation consisted in His being born in a low condition, made under the law, enduring the miseries of this life, the wrath of God, and the cursed death of the cross, and being buried, and continuing under the power of death for a time. <i>(His humiliation reveals the reality of His humanity; His obedience shows His divine power at work in flesh.)</i>	WLC 36–40 Q. 36 <i>Who is the Mediator of the covenant of grace?</i> A. The Lord Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, who became man and continues to be both God and man in two distinct natures and one person forever. Q. 37 - <i>How did Christ, being the Son of God, become man?</i> A. He took to Himself a true body and a reasonable soul, being conceived by the power of the Holy Spirit in the womb of the virgin Mary, and born of her, yet without sin. Q. 38–39 - <i>Why was it necessary that our Mediator should be God and man?</i> A. As man, that He might obey the law and suffer in our nature; as God, that His obedience and suffering might be of infinite value and power to satisfy God's justice, support our faith, and bring us to God.

CHRISTOLOGY – The Doctrine of Christ

The Offices of Christ

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 8.1, 8.8 It pleased God to ordain His Son, the Lord Jesus Christ, to be Mediator and Head of His Church, to execute the offices of Prophet, Priest, and King, both in His state of humiliation and exaltation. As Prophet, Christ reveals the will of God for our salvation through His Word and Spirit. He is the light of the world, who makes known the Father and declares truth to all generations. As Priest, He offered Himself once as a perfect sacrifice to satisfy divine justice, reconcile us to God, and make continual intercession for us. His priestly work is complete in atonement yet ongoing in advocacy and intercession for His people. As King, Christ subdues us to Himself, rules and defends His Church, and restrains and conquers all His and our enemies. His reign extends over all things, governing the hearts of His people and the nations of the earth for the glory of God.	WSC 23–26 Q. 23 <i>What offices does Christ execute as our Redeemer?</i> A. Christ executes the offices of a Prophet, of a Priest, and of a King, both in His humiliation and exaltation. Q. 24 - <i>How does Christ execute the office of a Prophet?</i> A. By revealing to us, through His Word and Spirit, the will of God for our salvation. Q. 25 <i>How does Christ execute the office of a Priest?</i> A. By offering Himself once as a sacrifice to satisfy divine justice and reconcile us to God, and by making continual intercession for us. Q. 26 - <i>How does Christ execute the office of a King?</i> A. By subduing us to Himself, ruling and defending us, and restraining and conquering all His and our enemies.	WLC 42–56 Q. 42 <i>Why is our Mediator called Christ?</i> A. Because He was anointed with the Holy Spirit beyond measure, and fully furnished to execute the offices of Prophet, Priest, and King. Q. 43–45 <i>How does Christ execute the office of a Prophet?</i> A. By revealing to the Church, in all ages, through His Word and Spirit, the full counsel of God concerning salvation and duty. Q. 44–47 <i>How does Christ execute the office of a Priest?</i> A. By once offering Himself as a sacrifice, making intercession continually, and applying His benefits to believers. Q. 48–56 - <i>How does Christ execute the office of a King?</i> A. By calling a people to Himself, giving them laws and officers, ruling in their hearts by His Word and Spirit, rewarding obedience, correcting sin, and subduing all opposition until all enemies are placed under His feet.

CHRISTOLOGY – The Doctrine of Christ

The States of Christ

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 8.4–8.5 The Lord Jesus, in His state of humiliation, was born in a low condition, made under the law, suffered the miseries of this life, endured the wrath of God and the cursed death of the cross, was buried, and continued under the power of death for a time. In His state of exaltation, He rose from the dead on the third day, ascended into heaven, sits at the right hand of the Father, and will return to judge the world at the last day. These two states form one continuous work of redemption. His humiliation reveals His obedience and love; His exaltation displays His triumph and lordship over all things. Through both, He accomplished salvation perfectly and reigns as the exalted Mediator for His people.	WSC 27–28 Q. 27 <i>Wherein did Christ's humiliation consist?</i> A. Christ's humiliation consisted in His being born in a low condition, made under the law, enduring the miseries of this life, the wrath of God, and the cursed death of the cross, being buried, and continuing under the power of death for a time. Q. 28 - <i>Wherein consists Christ's exaltation?</i> A. Christ's exaltation consists in His rising again from the dead on the third day, ascending up into heaven, sitting at the right hand of God the Father, and coming to judge the world at the last day.	WLC 46–56 Q. 46 <i>What was the estate of Christ's humiliation?</i> A. The estate of Christ's humiliation was His being born of a woman, made under the law, enduring the miseries of this life, the wrath of God, and the cursed death of the cross; in being buried, and continuing under the power of death until the third day. Q. 51–56 <i>What was the estate of Christ's exaltation?</i> A. The estate of Christ's exaltation includes His rising from the dead, ascending into heaven, sitting at the right hand of God the Father, and coming again to judge the world in righteousness at the last day. In His exaltation, He triumphs over sin and death, pours out gifts upon His people, and reigns as King forever.

CHRISTOLOGY – The Doctrine of Christ

God's Just Mercy in Christ

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 8.5; 11.1–11.3 Justice Satisfied: In His obedience and sacrifice of Himself, which He once offered to God through the eternal Spirit, the Lord Jesus fully satisfied divine justice, reconciling us to God and purchasing an everlasting inheritance for all whom the Father has given Him. God's justice demanded perfect obedience and a full payment for sin—requirements that only the God-man could meet. Mercy Applied: Those for whom Christ died are freely justified—not by anything done in them, but by God imputing to them the righteousness of Christ. This righteousness is received by faith alone, itself a gift of grace. Thus, in Christ, God shows mercy without compromising His justice. Glory Revealed: Through the cross, God's attributes shine in perfect harmony—His righteousness is displayed in punishing sin, His love in providing a substitute, and His faithfulness in keeping His covenant promises. The redeemed glorify God eternally as both just and merciful, worshiping the Lamb who was slain.	WSC 25, 33 Q. 25 <i>How does Christ execute the office of a Priest?</i> A. By offering Himself once as a sacrifice to satisfy divine justice, reconcile us to God, and make continual intercession for us. Q. 33 - <i>What is justification?</i> A. Justification is an act of God's free grace, wherein He pardons all our sins and accepts us as righteous in His sight, only for the righteousness of Christ imputed to us, and received by faith alone.	WLC 44, 70–73 Q. 44 - <i>How does Christ execute the office of a Priest?</i> A. Christ executes the office of a Priest in His once offering Himself to God as a sacrifice to satisfy divine justice and reconcile us to God, and in making continual intercession for us. Q. 70 - <i>What is justification?</i> A. Justification is an act of God's free grace to sinners, in which He pardons all their sins, accepts and accounts their persons righteous in His sight—not for anything wrought in them or done by them, but only for the perfect obedience and full satisfaction of Christ imputed to them and received by faith alone. Q. 71–73 <i>Why is justification an act of grace and not works?</i> A. Because even our faith is God's gift, so that boasting is excluded and all glory belongs to God, who is both just and merciful in Christ Jesus.

CHRISTOLOGY - The Doctrine of Christ

The Promises of the Gospel

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 7.3; 8.8; 14.2; 17.1–17.2 The promises of the Gospel are rooted in the Covenant of Grace, which God freely made with sinners through Jesus Christ. In this covenant, He promises to give His Holy Spirit to all those ordained to eternal life, enabling them to believe and persevere to the end. Through the work of Christ, the promises of God are “Yes and Amen.” Every promise—of forgiveness, righteousness, adoption, sanctification, and eternal life—is certain because it depends not on the believer’s strength but on God’s unchanging purpose and power. Believers may sometimes doubt or fall into sin, but the covenant remains sure: the Spirit preserves them in faith, restores them in repentance, and seals them until the day of redemption. Thus the Gospel does not merely offer salvation; it secures it in Christ for all whom the Father has given Him.	WSC 32, 36–38 Q. 32 <i>What benefits do they that are effectually called partake of in this life?</i> A. They that are effectually called partake in this life of justification, adoption, and sanctification, and the several benefits which in this life accompany or flow from them. Q. 36 <i>What are the benefits which in this life accompany or flow from justification, adoption, and sanctification?</i> A. Assurance of God’s love, peace of conscience, joy in the Holy Spirit, growth in grace, and perseverance therein to the end. Q. 38 <i>What benefits do believers receive from Christ at the resurrection?</i> A. At the resurrection, believers are raised up in glory and made perfectly blessed in the full enjoyment of God to all eternity.	WLC 32, 66, 79–80 Q. 32 <i>How is the grace of God manifested in the Covenant of Grace?</i> A. In that God freely provides and secures for His elect all things necessary for salvation—faith to receive Christ, perseverance to remain in Him, and glory to be revealed in the end. Q. 66 <i>What is effectual calling?</i> A. Effectual calling is the work of God’s Spirit, whereby He convinces us of sin and misery, enlightens our minds in the knowledge of Christ, and renews our wills, so that we embrace Jesus Christ as He is freely offered in the Gospel. Q. 79–80 <i>What is assurance of faith and perseverance?</i> A. True believers, being united to Christ, are kept by His power and Spirit through faith unto salvation. Their assurance may vary, yet it can never be wholly lost, for the foundation of God stands firm: He knows those who are His.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Common Grace and External Calling

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 10.1–10.4; 5.7 Common Grace: God shows goodness and kindness to all His creatures. He provides for the needs of every living thing, restrains sin in society, and allows even unbelievers to share in the benefits of culture, order, and human flourishing. These mercies display His patience and the riches of His forbearance, meant to lead people to repentance. Yet, apart from saving grace, they do not change the heart or bring salvation. External Calling: God also calls many outwardly through the preaching of the Gospel, inviting all to come to Christ and promising life to those who believe. This external call reveals God’s sincere compassion and leaves none with excuse. However, because of the hardness of the human heart, most resist this call and perish through unbelief. Only those whom God has chosen and inwardly renews by His Spirit respond in faith. The distinction between common grace and saving grace magnifies both the generosity of God’s mercy and the justice of His judgment.	WSC 31 Q. 31 <i>What is effectual calling?</i> A. Effectual calling is the work of God’s Spirit, whereby convincing us of our sin and misery, enlightening our minds in the knowledge of Christ, and renewing our wills, He persuades and enables us to embrace Jesus Christ, freely offered to us in the Gospel. <i>(By contrast, the external call is the hearing of the Gospel without the inward work of the Spirit.)</i>	WLC 67–68 Q. 67 <i>What is effectual calling?</i> A. Effectual calling is the work of God’s almighty power and grace, whereby He, out of His free and special love to His elect, and from nothing in them moving Him thereunto, does in His accepted time invite and draw them to Jesus Christ by His Word and Spirit, savingly enlightening their minds and renewing their wills, so that they embrace the grace offered in the Gospel. Q. 68 <i>Are all who are called by the Gospel effectually called?</i> A. All are outwardly called by the Gospel, but only those whom God has predestined to life are inwardly called and enabled to answer that call.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Effectual Calling and Regeneration

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 10.1–10.4; 13.1 Those whom God has predestined to life, He calls at His appointed time by His Word and Spirit, out of their state of sin and death into grace and salvation by Jesus Christ. In this effectual call, the Holy Spirit enlightens their minds to understand the truth, renews their wills, and draws them to Jesus Christ freely and willingly. Though they once resisted, they are now made willing by His grace. This inward work of the Spirit is known as regeneration—the new birth—whereby the sinner is made alive in Christ. It is not the result of human effort or merit, but the sovereign act of God, producing repentance, faith, and a new heart inclined toward holiness. Infants and others incapable of outward response may be regenerated by the Spirit as He wills. God’s Spirit works when, where, and how He pleases, always according to His eternal purpose and grace.	WSC 31 Q. 31 <i>What is effectual calling?</i> A. Effectual calling is the work of God’s Spirit, whereby convincing us of our sin and misery, enlightening our minds in the knowledge of Christ, and renewing our wills, He persuades and enables us to embrace Jesus Christ, freely offered to us in the Gospel. <i>(Regeneration is the inward renewal of the heart that makes this calling effective.)</i>	WLC 67–69; 75 Q. 67 - <i>What is effectual calling?</i> A. Effectual calling is the work of God’s almighty power and grace, whereby He draws the elect to Jesus Christ through His Word and Spirit, enlightening their minds, renewing their wills, and persuading and enabling them to embrace Him freely offered in the Gospel. Q. 68 <i>Are all who are called by the Gospel effectually called?</i> A. No; only those whom God has predestined to life are inwardly called and drawn to Christ by the Spirit. Q. 75 <i>What is sanctification?</i> A. Sanctification is the work of God’s grace whereby those who are regenerated are renewed in the whole person after the image of God and enabled more and more to die to sin and live to righteousness. <i>(Here regeneration flows into sanctification.)</i>

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Saving Faith

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 14.1–14.3 Faith Produced: The grace of faith, by which the elect believe to the saving of their souls, is the work of the Spirit of Christ in their hearts. It is ordinarily produced by the ministry of the Word, and by the same Word, together with the sacraments and prayer, it is increased and strengthened. Faith Exercised: By this faith, a Christian believes whatever is revealed in God’s Word because it is the authority of God Himself who speaks. Faith acts differently upon different parts of Scripture—believing promises, obeying commands, and trembling at warnings—but its central act is receiving and resting upon Christ alone for justification, sanctification, and eternal life. Faith Fruitful: Though weak or strong, faith grows through trials, obedience, and communion with God. True faith works by love, purifies the heart, overcomes the world, and brings forth good works as its natural fruit.	WSC 86–87 Q. 86 <i>What is faith in Jesus Christ?</i> A. Faith in Jesus Christ is a saving grace, whereby we receive and rest upon Him alone for salvation, as He is offered to us in the Gospel. Q. 87 <i>- What is repentance unto life?</i> A. Repentance unto life is a saving grace, whereby a sinner, out of a true sense of his sin and apprehension of the mercy of God in Christ, turns from it unto God with full purpose of, and endeavor after, new obedience. <i>(Faith and repentance are twin graces of new life.)</i>	WLC 72–73; 155 Q. 72 <i>- What is justifying faith?</i> A. Justifying faith is a saving grace, wrought in the heart of a sinner by the Spirit and Word of God, whereby he is convinced of his sin and misery, and of the inability of himself and all others to save him; and so, not only assents to the truth of the promise of the Gospel, but receives and rests upon Christ and His righteousness therein held forth for pardon of sin, and for the accepting and accounting of his person righteous before God. Q. 73 <i>- How does faith justify a sinner?</i> A. Faith justifies not because it is a good work, but as the instrument by which the sinner receives and applies Christ and His righteousness. Q. 155 <i>- How is the Word made effectual to salvation?</i> A. The Spirit of God makes the reading and especially the preaching of the Word an effectual means of convincing and converting sinners, and of building them up in holiness and comfort through faith unto salvation.

The Doctrine of Salvation

Justification

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
Stage 1 – The Act of Justification WCF 11.1–11.2 Justification is an act of God’s free grace. From all eternity, God decreed to justify all who are in Christ, and in time He effectually calls and declares them righteous. He freely pardons all their sins and accepts them as righteous—not for anything done by them, but only for the righteousness of Christ imputed to them and received by faith alone. This righteousness consists of Christ’s perfect obedience and full satisfaction for sin, both in His life and death, credited to believers by God’s gracious decree. Faith, resting on Christ alone, is the sole instrument of justification; yet it is never alone in the person justified, but is always accompanied by all other saving graces and produces good works. Stage 2 – The Fruit of Justification	WSC 33–36 Q. 33 <i>What is justification?</i> A. Justification is an act of God’s free grace, wherein He pardons all our sins and accepts us as righteous in His sight, only for the righteousness of Christ imputed to us and received by faith alone. Q. 36 <i>What are the benefits which in this life accompany or flow from justification, adoption, and sanctification?</i> A. The benefits in this life are assurance of God’s love, peace of conscience, joy in the Holy Spirit, growth in grace, and perseverance therein to the end.	WLC 70–73; 77–79 Q. 70 <i>What is justification?</i> A. Justification is an act of God’s free grace to sinners, in which He pardons all their sins, accepts and accounts their persons righteous in His sight—not for anything wrought in them or done by them, but only for the perfect obedience and full satisfaction of Christ imputed to them and received by faith alone. Q. 71- <i>How is justification an act of free grace?</i> A. Because it proceeds not from anything in man, but from God’s pure favor and love, who accepts Christ’s righteousness for sinners. Q. 77 - <i>Wherein do justification and sanctification differ?</i> A. Justification is a one-time legal act freeing the sinner from condemnation; sanctification is a continual work renewing the heart and life. Q. 79 <i>What assurance of justification do believers have?</i> A. True believers may, by faith, be assured that they are justified and at peace with God, rejoicing in the hope of His glory.

WCF 11.3–11.5

Justification brings peace with God, freedom from condemnation, and access into grace. Though believers may fall into sin and incur God's fatherly displeasure, their justification is never lost because it depends entirely on Christ's obedience and intercession. Thus God's justice is satisfied, His mercy displayed, and the believer's joy secured forever in the finished work of Christ.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Sanctification

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
Stage 1 – Definitive Sanctification WCF 13.1 All who are effectually called and regenerated are, by God’s Word and Spirit dwelling in them, definitively set apart from the dominion of sin and consecrated to God. This work flows from union with Christ in His death and resurrection. The power of reigning sin is destroyed, and the believer is no longer a slave to corruption but becomes a servant of righteousness. Sanctification begins at conversion as a decisive act of divine grace: God separates His people from the world, renews their hearts, and declares them holy in Christ Jesus. Stage 2 – Progressive Sanctification WCF 13.2–13.3 Though the dominion of sin is destroyed, its presence remains. Therefore, sanctification is a continual process by which the Spirit increases holiness in the believer, strengthening every grace and enabling them to pursue righteousness. In this lifelong struggle, the flesh wars against the Spirit, and believers often fall into sin, yet they are renewed to repentance and strengthened in faith. By the Spirit’s power, they grow in love, humility, patience, and obedience. This process will never be perfect in this life but will be completed in glory when believers are made fully like Christ.	WSC 35 Q. 35 - <i>What is sanctification?</i> A. Sanctification is the work of God’s free grace, whereby we are renewed in the whole man after the image of God and are enabled more and more to die unto sin and live unto righteousness. <i>(Definitive sanctification begins this renewal through union with Christ.)</i> WSC 36, 82 Q. 36 <i>What are the benefits which in this life accompany or flow from justification, adoption, and sanctification?</i> A. Assurance of God’s love, peace of conscience, joy in the Holy Spirit, growth in grace, and perseverance to the end. Q. 82 - <i>Is any man able perfectly to keep the commandments of God?</i> A. No mere man, since the fall, is able perfectly to keep the commandments of God, but daily breaks them in thought, word, and deed.	WLC 75–77 Q. 75 <i>What is sanctification?</i> A. Sanctification is a work of God’s grace, whereby those who are regenerated are renewed in the whole man after the image of God and enabled more and more to die unto sin and live unto righteousness. Q. 76 <i>What is the difference between justification and sanctification?</i> A. In justification, sin is pardoned; in sanctification, it is subdued. The one is an act of God’s grace once for all, the other a continual work of His grace in believers. WLC 77–79, 195 Q. 77 <i>Wherein do justification and sanctification differ?</i> A. Justification is an act of God’s grace once for all; sanctification is a continual work. Q. 78 <i>Why do believers not become perfectly holy in this life?</i>

		A. Because sin remains in them and they are often overcome by temptation, though through Christ's Spirit they continually renew repentance and grow in grace. Q. 195 - <i>What do we pray for in "Thy kingdom come"?</i> A. That the kingdom of grace may be advanced in ourselves and others, until the kingdom of glory is fully perfected.
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SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Adoption

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
Stage 1 – Adoption Declared WCF 12; 11.1 All those who are justified, God graciously receives and counts as His children. In Christ, they are no longer under condemnation but share the same legal standing before God as sons and daughters of the King. This act of adoption is a judicial declaration of God’s free grace, founded entirely upon the finished work of Christ and received through faith. The believer’s status is changed from alien to heir, from enemy to beloved child. Stage 2 – Adoption Enjoyed WCF 12; 17.2; 18.1–18.3 Having been received as children, believers enjoy the privileges of God’s household. The Holy Spirit bears witness with their spirits that they are children of God, enabling them to cry, “Abba, Father.” They experience the Father’s care, correction, and compassion; they receive access to His throne in prayer and the inheritance of His promises. Even through discipline, their Father works all things for their good. Though they may struggle with doubt or fear, the foundation of adoption never changes—God’s love is steadfast, and His seal of sonship cannot be broken.	WSC 34 Q. 34 <i>What is adoption?</i> A. Adoption is an act of God’s free grace, whereby we are received into the number and have a right to all the privileges of the sons of God. WSC 36 Q. 36 <i>What are the benefits which in this life accompany or flow from justification, adoption, and sanctification?</i> A. Assurance of God’s love, peace of conscience, joy in the Holy Spirit, growth in grace, and perseverance therein to the end.	WLC 74 Q. 74 - <i>What is adoption?</i> A. Adoption is an act of God’s free grace, in and for His only Son Jesus Christ, whereby all those that are justified are received into the family of God, have His name put upon them, the Spirit of His Son given to them, are under His fatherly care and dispensations, admitted to all the liberties and privileges of the children of God, made heirs of all the promises, and fellow-heirs with Christ in glory. WLC 80, 182 Q. 80 <i>Can true believers fall away from the state of grace?</i> A. Those whom God has accepted in His Beloved, effectually called, and sanctified by His Spirit, can neither totally nor finally fall away from the state of grace, but shall certainly persevere therein to the end, and be eternally saved. Q. 182 - <i>How does the Spirit help believers in prayer?</i> A. The Spirit helps our infirmities by enabling us to cry, “Abba, Father,” and by making intercession within us according to the will of God.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Repentance and Conversion

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 15.1–15.6 Repentance Defined: Repentance unto life is a saving grace, worked in the heart of a sinner by the Spirit and Word of God. In it the sinner, out of a true sense of sin and an apprehension of God’s mercy in Christ, turns from sin unto God with grief and hatred of it, resolving and striving, by grace, to walk with Him in new obedience. Repentance and Conversion United: This turning is inseparable from faith in Jesus Christ. The same Spirit who convinces the heart of sin also draws it to Christ for cleansing and life. Thus, repentance is not mere remorse but the inward renewal of mind and heart that produces outward change. The Ongoing Grace: Although repentance is required of all, no sin is so great that it can bring condemnation on those who truly repent. Because believers continue to sin daily, repentance remains a lifelong duty and grace, expressing continual dependence upon God’s mercy and renewing fellowship with Him.	WSC 87, 88 Q. 87 <i>What is repentance unto life?</i> A. Repentance unto life is a saving grace, whereby a sinner, out of a true sense of his sin and apprehension of the mercy of God in Christ, does, with grief and hatred of his sin, turn from it unto God with full purpose of, and endeavor after, new obedience. Q. 88 <i>What are the outward and ordinary means whereby Christ communicates to us the benefits of redemption?</i> A. The outward and ordinary means are His ordinances, especially the Word, sacraments, and prayer; all of which are made effectual to the elect for salvation. <i>(Repentance is nourished through these means.)</i>	WLC 76, 153–155 Q. 76 <i>What is repentance unto life?</i> A. Repentance unto life is a saving grace, wrought in the heart of a sinner by the Word and Spirit of God, whereby, out of the sight and sense of the danger and filthiness of sin, and the apprehension of God’s mercy in Christ, he grieves for and hates his sins, turns from them all to God, purposing and endeavoring constantly to walk with Him in all the ways of new obedience. Q. 153–155 <i>How is repentance produced and maintained?</i> A. The Spirit of God makes the reading and preaching of the Word effectual to convince and convert sinners and to build them up in holiness and comfort through faith and repentance unto salvation.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Good Works

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 16.1–16.7 The Nature of Good Works: Good works are only those that God has commanded in His Word, not works devised by human imagination or tradition. They are the fruit of a true and living faith, performed out of love and gratitude to God, in obedience to His revealed will. The Source of Good Works: Good works cannot earn pardon of sin or eternal life; they are entirely the result of God's grace. Even our best works, being imperfect and tainted by sin, cannot endure His judgment apart from Christ. Yet, because believers are accepted in the Beloved, their works are also accepted and pleasing to God through Him. The Purpose of Good Works: Though not the ground of salvation, good works confirm our faith, build up our assurance, edify others, silence opponents, and glorify God. They are evidence that we have passed from death to life and that the Spirit of God dwells within us. True faith is never barren but works by love and produces obedience as its necessary and joyful fruit.	WSC 86 Q. 86 <i>What is faith in Jesus Christ?</i> A. Faith in Jesus Christ is a saving grace, whereby we receive and rest upon Him alone for salvation, as He is offered to us in the Gospel. <i>(This faith naturally brings forth good works as its evidence.)</i>	WLC 73, 78–79 Q. 73 - <i>How does faith justify a sinner?</i> A. Faith justifies not because it is a good work, but as the instrument by which the sinner receives and applies Christ and His righteousness. Yet the faith that justifies is never alone—it is always accompanied by good works. Q. 78 <i>Why do believers not become perfectly holy in this life?</i> A. Because sin remains in them, and they are often overcome by temptation; yet through Christ's Spirit, they continually renew repentance and grow in obedience. Q. 79 - <i>What assurance do believers have of their good works?</i> A. Though their best works cannot merit salvation, believers find in them evidence of grace, encouragement to thankfulness, and reason to glorify God for His sanctifying power.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Perseverance

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 17.1–17.3 Those whom God has accepted in His Beloved, effectually called, and sanctified by His Spirit can never completely or finally fall away from the state of grace. They shall certainly persevere in faith to the end and be eternally saved. This perseverance does not depend on human will or effort but on the unchangeable purpose of God, the merit and intercession of Christ, the abiding presence of the Spirit, and the nature of the covenant of grace—all of which guarantee that true believers will be kept by God’s power through faith unto salvation. Although believers may fall into grievous sin and for a time lose their sense of comfort and assurance, God continues to uphold them, renews them to repentance, and restores their joy. The perseverance of the saints rests entirely upon the faithfulness of God, not the performance of man.	WSC 36 Q. 36 <i>What are the benefits which in this life accompany or flow from justification, adoption, and sanctification?</i> A. Assurance of God’s love, peace of conscience, joy in the Holy Spirit, growth in grace, and perseverance therein to the end.	WLC 79–80 Q. 79 <i>May not true believers, by reason of their sins, fall away from the state of grace?</i> A. True believers may fall into grievous sins and for a time continue therein, thereby incurring God’s fatherly displeasure and losing some measure of His grace and comfort. Q. 80 <i>- Can true believers fall totally and finally away from the state of grace?</i> A. No. Those whom God has accepted in Christ and sanctified by His Spirit can neither totally nor finally fall away, but shall certainly persevere to the end and be eternally saved.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Assurance

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 18.1–18.4 Ground of Assurance: True believers may, in this life, attain to an infallible assurance of faith founded on the divine truth of God’s promises, the inward evidence of grace in their hearts, and the witness of the Spirit of adoption confirming their sonship. Nature of Assurance: This assurance does not rest on special revelation but on the promises of God applied by the Holy Spirit. It is not mere presumption or imagination but a Spirit-wrought confidence that flows from communion with Christ. Certainty and Variability: Assurance may grow, weaken, or be shaken by temptation, sin, or neglect of the means of grace. Yet the seed of God remains in the believer, and by the Spirit’s renewing work, assurance is revived and strengthened again. End of Assurance: This grace leads to humility, love, and perseverance — not to carelessness — for those who know God’s faithful keeping find renewed zeal for holiness and worship.	WSC 36 Q. 36 <i>What are the benefits which in this life accompany or flow from justification, adoption, and sanctification?</i> A. The benefits in this life are assurance of God’s love, peace of conscience, joy in the Holy Spirit, growth in grace, and perseverance therein to the end.	WLC 80, 172–175 Q. 80 <i>Can true believers fall away from the state of grace?</i> A. Those whom God has accepted in His Beloved, effectually called, and sanctified by His Spirit, can neither totally nor finally fall away from the state of grace, but shall certainly persevere therein to the end. Q. 172–175 - <i>What is required to the right receiving of the Lord’s Supper, and what fruit does it bring?</i> A. Those who partake worthily, discerning the Lord’s body and trusting in His promises, grow in assurance of God’s love and in joy through communion with Christ. Thus assurance is nourished through the means of grace, not gained apart from them.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

The Law of God

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 19.1–19.7 Threefold Division: God gave His law to Adam as a covenant of works, requiring perfect obedience and promising life for fulfillment and death for disobedience. After the fall, the law continued to reveal God’s will and bind all people to obedience. There are three kinds of law in Scripture: the moral, ceremonial, and civil. • The moral law, summarily comprehended in the Ten Commandments, is perpetual and binds all men in every age. • The ceremonial law governed Israel’s worship and foreshadowed Christ’s priestly work; it was fulfilled and abrogated in Him. • The civil or judicial law applied moral principles to Israel’s society; it expired with the theocracy, though its general equity remains useful. Three Uses: 1. To Convict: The law shows sinners their guilt, revealing their inability and driving them to Christ for salvation. 2. To Restrain: The law restrains evil through fear of punishment and maintains civil order. 3. To Guide: The law serves as a rule of life for believers, showing	WSC 39–44, 82 Q. 39 <i>What is the duty which God requires of man?</i> A. The duty which God requires of man is obedience to His revealed will. Q. 40 <i>What did God at first reveal to man for the rule of his obedience?</i> A. The moral law. Q. 41 <i>Where is the moral law summarily comprehended?</i> A. In the Ten Commandments. Q. 82 <i>- Is any man able perfectly to keep the commandments of God?</i> A. No mere man since the fall is able in this life perfectly to keep the commandments of God, but daily breaks them in thought, word, and deed.	WLC 91–97 Q. 91 <i>What is the duty which God requires of man?</i> A. Obedience to His revealed will. Q. 92 <i>What did God reveal to man for the rule of obedience?</i> A. The moral law. Q. 93 <i>What is the moral law?</i> A. The moral law is the declaration of the will of God to mankind, directing and binding everyone to obedience, according to the nature of the creature and the relationship he bears to God. Q. 94 <i>Is there any use of the law to man since the fall?</i> A. Although no man can be justified by the law, it serves to show the holiness of God, the sinfulness of man, and our need for Christ; to restrain sin; and to guide the regenerate in thankful obedience. Q. 95–97 - <i>What is the moral law’s relationship to believers?</i> A. It remains a perfect rule of righteousness, revealing God’s character and will. Though believers are freed from the curse of the law, they are not freed from obedience to it, but rather enabled by grace to delight in it.

the will of God and leading to grateful obedience. Harmony of Law and Gospel: Although believers are not under the law as a covenant of works, the moral law remains a reflection of God's holy character and a delight to those renewed by grace.		
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SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

The Ten Commandments (In Brief)

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 19.2; 19.5–19.7 God’s moral law, summarized in the Ten Commandments, binds all people, believers and unbelievers alike, forever. Though Christians are no longer under the law as a covenant of works, they remain under it as a rule of life, revealing the will of God for gratitude and obedience. The Ten Commandments teach us to love God wholly and our neighbor sincerely. They were first written on Adam’s heart, then given by God’s voice and finger on Mount Sinai, and continue as the perfect summary of righteousness. The commandments convict of sin, lead us to Christ, and then guide us in thankful obedience. Each commandment requires the full extent of duty it implies and forbids not only the external act but every sinful thought, motive, or omission contrary to it.	WSC 45–81 Overview: The Ten Commandments are divided into two tables—the first four commands teach our duty to God; the last six teach our duty to man. Key Teachings: • <i>First Commandment</i> — Worship and serve God alone (Q.45–48). • <i>Second Commandment</i> — Worship God only as He commands; avoid idolatry and images (Q.49–52). • <i>Third Commandment</i> — Honor God’s name, attributes, and works with reverence and truth (Q.53–56). • <i>Fourth Commandment</i> — Keep the Sabbath day holy, resting from sin and worldly work and delighting in worship (Q.57–62).	WLC 103–148 Overview: The Larger Catechism expands the Ten Commandments to reveal the full depth of God’s law—each commandment includes duties required and sins forbidden. The law is spiritual, reaching the heart and motives as well as outward acts. Key Themes: • <i>First Commandment</i> (Q.104–106) — Calls for knowing, trusting, loving, fearing, and honoring God above all. • <i>Second Commandment</i> (Q.107–110) — Commands pure worship and forbids false images or any worship not appointed by God. • <i>Third Commandment</i> (Q.111–114) — Requires reverence for God’s name, His Word, and His works; forbids profaning or misusing them. • <i>Fourth Commandment</i> (Q.115–121) — Sets apart one day in seven as holy to the Lord; commands holy rest and worship.

	• <i>Fifth Commandment</i> — Honor and obey parents and lawful authorities (Q.63–66). • <i>Sixth Commandment</i> — Preserve life in ourselves and others; avoid murder, hatred, or neglect (Q.67–69). • <i>Seventh Commandment</i> — Keep purity in heart, speech, and conduct; flee adultery and lust (Q.70–72). • <i>Eighth Commandment</i> — Protect property and promote justice; avoid theft, greed, and waste (Q.73–75). • <i>Ninth Commandment</i> — Speak truthfully; protect the good name of others; avoid lies, slander, and gossip (Q.76–78). • <i>Tenth Commandment</i> — Be content in all circumstances; root out envy and covetous desire (Q.79–81).	• <i>Fifth Commandment</i> (Q.123–133) — Governs all relationships of authority and obedience—family, church, and society. • <i>Sixth Commandment</i> (Q.134–136) — Requires preserving life and forbids all unjust harm or neglect of ourselves or others. • <i>Seventh Commandment</i> (Q.137–139) — Requires chastity in heart, speech, and behavior; forbids impurity and lust in all forms. • <i>Eighth Commandment</i> (Q.140–142) — Requires justice and mercy in business and property; forbids fraud, greed, and waste. • <i>Ninth Commandment</i> (Q.143–145) — Requires truth, charity, and defense of our neighbor’s reputation; forbids lies, slander, and false witness. • <i>Tenth Commandment</i> (Q.146–148) — Requires contentment and gratitude; forbids envy, covetousness, and discontent with God’s providence. Summary: The Ten Commandments reveal the moral perfection of God and expose human sin, driving us to Christ, who perfectly fulfilled the law and enables His people to walk in holiness.
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SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

The Ten Commandments (Fuller Treatment)

Source	Harmonized Content
WSC 39–44; WLC 91–99	What God requires: obedience to His revealed will; the rule is the moral law, summarized in the Ten Commandments; their sum is love for God and neighbor. The preface (“I am the LORD your God who brought you out...”) teaches God’s authority, covenant mercy, and redeeming grace—therefore we must keep all His commands. The rules for understanding include: the law is perfect and binds the whole person; it is spiritual (reaches thoughts, motives, words, acts); duties imply the opposite sins are forbidden and vice-versa; one command may include many related duties; what’s commanded or forbidden extends to all proper means and occasions.

First Commandment

Wording & Scope	Duties Required	Sins Forbidden
“You shall have no other gods before Me.” (exclusive worship)	Know, acknowledge, and confess the only true God as our God; worship and glorify Him accordingly; think on Him, remember, esteem, honor, adore, choose, love, desire, fear, trust, hope, delight, rejoice, be zealous for Him; call on Him, praise and thank Him; submit with whole-person obedience; aim to please Him, sorrow when He is offended; walk humbly with Him.	Denying God, failing to worship and glorify Him as God, or giving worship and glory that belong to Him to any other.

Second Commandment

Wording & Scope	Duties Required	Sins Forbidden	Reasons Annexed
“You shall not make... any image... you shall not bow down to them or serve them.” (regulative worship)	Receive, observe, and keep pure and whole all worship and ordinances God instituted (Word read & preached, prayer & thanks, sacraments, church government/discipline, the ministry and its support, fasting, lawful oaths and vows). Disapprove, oppose, and, within one’s calling, remove false worship and monuments of idolatry.	Worshipping God by images or any way not appointed in His Word.	God’s sovereign right over us, His jealousy , and His covenant mercy to thousands who love Him and keep His commands.

Third Commandment

Wording & Scope	Duties Required	Sins Forbidden	Reasons Annexed
“You shall not take the name of the LORD your God in vain.” (reverence for all by which God makes Himself known)	Holy, reverent use of God’s name, titles, attributes, Word, sacraments, prayer, oaths, vows, lots, works—in thought, meditation, speech, and writing—with a profession and conduct that glorify God and edify others.	All profaning or abusing of anything by which God reveals Himself (e.g., rash oaths, frivolous God-talk, hypocrisy, superstitious or corrupt use of His works/Word).	Because He is the LORD our God and will not hold guiltless those who take His name in vain—His judgment underscores the weight of this command.

Fourth Commandment

Wording & Scope	What Required	How to Keep	Sins Forbidden	Reasons Annexed	Why “Remember”?
“Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy.” (one day in seven for holy rest and worship)	God requires sanctifying set times, expressly one whole day in seven. From creation to Christ’s resurrection it was the seventh day; since the resurrection it is the first day (the Lord’s Day), to continue to the end of the world.	Holy resting all the day from worldly employments and recreations; delighting in public and private worship; allowing works of necessity and mercy; preparing hearts and ordering affairs beforehand to be free for the day’s duties.	Omission or careless performance of duties; profaning the day by idleness; doing what is sinful in itself; or needless thoughts, words, or works about worldly employments and recreations.	God gives six days and reserves one; He claims a special propriety in the day; His own example in creation; and His blessing on the day for our good.	We easily forget it; it helps us prepare, and keeping it helps us keep the rest; it preserves thankful remembrance of creation and redemption and restrains natural liberty; Satan labors to blot it out.

Fifth Commandment

Wording & Scope	Duties Required	Sins Forbidden	Larger Catechism Emphasis
“Honor your father and your mother...” (all relations of authority)	Preserve honor and perform duties owed to superiors, inferiors, and equals fitting each relation.	Neglect of, or acting against, the honor and duty due in our various relations.	WLC expounds who counts as “father and mother,” the mutual duties of authorities and those under them, and the promise tied to the command.

Sixth Commandment

Wording & Scope	Duties Required (preserving life)	Sins Forbidden (unjust harm)
“You shall not murder.”	Preserve our own life and our neighbor’s—by just, prudent care; patient, charitable spirit; protection and relief of the distressed. <i>(WLC 134–135 in book’s section)</i>	Unjust taking of life; sinful anger, hatred, malice; anything that tends toward harm (rashness, neglect, cruelty, provoking, oppressive practices). <i>(WLC 136 in book’s section)</i>

Seventh Commandment

Wording & Scope	Duties Required (chastity)	Sins Forbidden (impurity)
“You shall not commit adultery.”	Chastity in heart, speech, and behavior; faithful marriage; watchfulness against temptations; modesty and temperance. <i>(WLC 138)</i>	Adultery, fornication, lust in heart or look; corrupt or suggestive speech; immodesty; any cause or occasion of uncleanness. <i>(WLC 139)</i>

Eighth Commandment

Wording & Scope	Duties Required (justice & mercy in estates)	Sins Forbidden (theft & greed)
“You shall not steal.”	Lawful procuring and furthering of our own and our neighbor’s wealth and outward estate by just diligence, truth, frugality, and generosity. <i>(WLC 141)</i>	Theft, fraud, unjust weights, waste, covetousness, idleness, oppression—any way of wronging our neighbor’s estate. <i>(WLC 142)</i>

Ninth Commandment

Wording & Scope	Duties Required (truth & charity)	Sins Forbidden (false witness)
“You shall not bear false witness.”	Preserving and promoting truth between man and man; good name of our neighbor; charitable judgment; speaking truth in love. <i>(WLC 144–145 structure reflected in book)</i>	Lies, slander, gossip, rash judging, flattering or backbiting, concealing truth when justice or the good of others requires it, or speaking truth unseasonably or maliciously. <i>(WLC 145)</i>

Tenth Commandment (+ Application)

Wording & Scope	Duty of Contentment	Why Preach the Law Strictly?
“You shall not covet.”	Hate even the smallest sinful desire; love and delight in all righteousness; practice contentment with God’s providence.	

Moral Law in Christian Life (Harmony note)

The moral law binds all people forever as a rule of life; believers are not under it as a covenant of works but **delight in it** through the Spirit. The law convicts of sin, restrains evil, and guides the regenerate in thankful obedience, strengthening—not weakening—Christian holiness.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

Christian Liberty

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 20.1–20.4 The Nature of Christian Liberty: Christ has purchased true liberty for believers. By His obedience and death, He has freed them from the guilt of sin, from God’s condemning wrath, from the curse of the moral law, and from the yoke of the ceremonial law. He delivers them from bondage to Satan and the dominion of sin, from the evil of afflictions, the sting of death, the victory of the grave, and everlasting damnation. This liberty also includes access to God, and the free, childlike service of Him in love rather than slavish fear. Believers now obey not as those under the law’s curse but as those moved by the Spirit of adoption. Liberty of Conscience: God alone is Lord of the conscience and has left it free from doctrines and commandments of men that are contrary to or beside His Word. To believe or obey such human requirements as divine authority is to betray true liberty of conscience. Likewise, using liberty as an excuse for sin or disorder is a perversion of the Gospel. The Bounds of Liberty: Christian liberty does not abolish rightful authority. Civil and ecclesiastical	WSC 82–84 Q. 82 - <i>Is any man able perfectly to keep the commandments of God?</i> A. No mere man, since the fall, is able perfectly to keep the commandments of God, but daily breaks them in thought, word, and deed. Q. 83 - <i>Are all transgressions equally heinous?</i> A. Some sins, because of their nature and circumstances, are more grievous in the sight of God than others. Q. 84 - <i>What does every sin deserve?</i> A. Every sin deserves God’s wrath and curse, both in this life and in that which is to come. <i>(These questions remind believers that liberty is not license but deliverance from condemnation to new obedience.)</i>	WLC 97, 105, 149–151 Q. 97 - <i>What special use does the moral law have for the regenerate?</i> A. Though believers are freed from the law as a covenant of works, it is still of great use to show them how much they are bound to Christ, who fulfilled it for them, and to direct them in thankful obedience. Q. 105 <i>What are the sins forbidden in the first commandment?</i> A. One of them is making men’s traditions or devices the rule of faith and worship instead of God’s Word. Q. 149–151 - <i>Is any man able perfectly to keep the commandments of God?</i> A. No man is able, either of himself or by any grace received in this life, perfectly to keep them. This reminds us that freedom is not perfection but the Spirit’s enabling to pursue holiness within grace.

power remain, each in its place, under Christ. Believers are to submit to lawful commands and maintain good order, provided those commands do not require sin.

The Goal of Liberty: Christ has set His people free that they might serve God in holiness and joy, glorifying Him in body and soul. True freedom is found not in autonomy but in glad obedience to the will of God.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

The Public and Private Worship of God

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 21.1–21.8	WSC 49–62; 104–107	WLC 104–121; 186–196
The Principle of Worship: The light of nature shows that there is a God who has lordship and sovereignty over all. He is good and does good to all, and therefore is to be feared, loved, praised, called upon, trusted, and served. But the acceptable way of worshiping the true God is established by Himself and limited to what He commands in His Word. He may not be worshiped according to human imagination or invention, under any visible representation, or by any other way not appointed in Scripture. The Object of Worship: Religious worship is due to God alone — the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit — and to Him alone, not to angels, saints, or any other creature. Since the fall, worship is not accepted without a Mediator, and Christ is that one Mediator. The Elements of Worship: God is to be worshiped in Spirit and in truth by the reading of Scripture, the sound preaching and hearing of the Word, the singing of psalms, the administration and receiving of the sacraments, prayer with thanksgiving, lawful oaths and vows, fasting, and solemn assemblies. These are to	Q. 49–52 <i>What does the second commandment require and forbid?</i> A. It requires the receiving, observing, and keeping pure all God’s ordinances of worship; forbids worshiping God by images or in any way not appointed in His Word. Q. 57–62 <i>What is required in the fourth commandment?</i> A. Keeping the Sabbath holy by resting from worldly employments and delighting in the worship of God. Q. 104–107 <i>What do we pray for in the first petitions of the Lord’s Prayer?</i> A. That God’s name be hallowed, His kingdom advanced, and His will done in us and by us as in heaven. Worship is the chief means by which these petitions are realized.	Q. 104–121 <i>How do the first four commandments govern worship?</i> A. They require knowing and honoring God, worshiping Him purely, revering His name, and sanctifying His day. Q. 108–110 <i>What does the second commandment teach about worship?</i> A. That only what God commands is lawful; all images and innovations are forbidden. Q. 185–196 <i>What do the petitions of the Lord’s Prayer teach about worship?</i> A. True worship prays that God’s name be hallowed, His kingdom come, and His will be done. We seek daily bread, forgiveness, and deliverance as acts of dependence and adoration, closing with praise: “For Thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory.” Summary: Worship is the believer’s highest calling — personal, familial, and corporate — regulated by God’s Word, centered on Christ, and empowered by the Spirit.

be offered with understanding, faith, reverence, and godly fear.

The Time and Place of Worship:

God is to be worshiped everywhere, both privately and publicly. Families and individuals must daily worship God in secret and together. Yet He also calls His people to gather publicly on the Lord's Day, the Christian Sabbath, and at other times as Providence allows. On this day, believers rest from ordinary employments and recreate their souls in worship and fellowship.

The Attitude of Worship:

Worship must be rendered with reverence, humility, and joy. We come not to perform but to meet with the living God through Christ. In all, God's glory and our spiritual edification are the goal.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

The Means of Grace – The Word of God

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 14.1–14.3; 21.5 The Necessity and Power of the Word: The Word of God is the outward and ordinary means by which Christ communicates the benefits of redemption. It is necessary for knowledge of God, for faith in Christ, and for growth in holiness. The Ministry of the Word: The reading of Scripture, sound preaching, and conscientious hearing of the Word are central acts of worship. Through them, God calls sinners to Himself and strengthens believers in faith and obedience. The Efficacy of the Word: The Spirit of God makes the reading and especially the preaching of the Word effectual to convince and convert sinners, and to build them up in comfort and holiness through faith unto salvation. The Word never returns void; it always accomplishes the purpose for which God sends it.	WSC 88–90 Q. 88 <i>What are the outward and ordinary means whereby Christ communicates to us the benefits of redemption?</i> A. The outward and ordinary means are His ordinances, especially the Word, sacraments, and prayer; all of which are made effectual to the elect for salvation. Q. 89 <i>How is the Word made effectual to salvation?</i> A. The Spirit of God makes the reading and especially the preaching of the Word an effectual means of convincing and converting sinners, and of building them up in holiness and comfort through faith unto salvation. Q. 90 <i>How should the Word be read and heard, that it may become effectual to salvation?</i> A. With diligence, preparation, prayer, faith, love, humility, and a desire to obey and apply it to our lives.	WLC 154–160 Q. 154 <i>What are the outward means whereby Christ communicates the benefits of His mediation?</i> A. The outward and ordinary means are His ordinances, especially the Word, sacraments, and prayer. Q. 155 <i>How is the Word made effectual to salvation?</i> A. The Spirit of God makes the reading and especially the preaching of the Word an effectual means of enlightening, convincing, and humbling sinners, driving them to Christ, and building up believers in holiness and comfort through faith unto salvation. Q. 157–160 <i>How should the Word be preached, and how should it be received?</i> A. It should be preached soundly, faithfully, and with zeal for God’s glory and souls’ good. It should be received with understanding, faith, and love; meditated upon, hidden in the heart, and lived out in obedience.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

The Means of Grace – The Sacraments

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 27.1–27.5	WSC 91–97	WLC 161–177
The Nature of the Sacraments: Sacraments are holy signs and seals of the covenant of grace, instituted by Christ to represent Him and His benefits, and to confirm our interest in Him. They visibly distinguish the Church from the world and solemnly bind believers to God and one another. The Operation of the Sacraments: The efficacy of a sacrament does not depend upon the holiness of the minister, nor upon the outward act itself, but upon the working of the Holy Spirit and the faith of the recipient. The Number and Design: There are only two sacraments ordained by Christ—Baptism and the Lord’s Supper—which correspond to entrance and nourishment in the covenant of grace. Both are means of grace and marks of belonging to Christ’s visible Church.	Q. 91 <i>How do the sacraments become effectual means of salvation?</i> A. Not by any power in them or in the one administering them, but only by the blessing of Christ and the working of His Spirit in those who receive them by faith. Q. 92 <i>What is a sacrament?</i> A. A sacrament is a holy ordinance instituted by Christ; in it, by sensible signs, Christ and the benefits of the new covenant are represented, sealed, and applied to believers. Q. 93 <i>Which are the sacraments of the New Testament?</i> A. Baptism and the Lord’s Supper.	Q. 161 <i>What is a sacrament?</i> A. A sacrament is a holy ordinance instituted by Christ, wherein, by outward and visible signs, Christ and His benefits are represented, sealed, and applied to believers. Q. 162–163 <i>Who may receive the sacraments?</i> A. Only those who are within the covenant of grace and profess faith in Christ and obedience to Him. Q. 165–177 <i>What are the specific purposes of Baptism and the Lord’s Supper?</i> A. Baptism signifies and seals our ingrafting into Christ, regeneration, and cleansing from sin. The Lord’s Supper signifies and seals our communion with Christ’s body and blood for spiritual nourishment and growth in grace. Summary: The sacraments are visible words of the Gospel—signs that preach grace, seals that confirm faith, and ordinances that nourish believers in union with Christ.

SOTERIOLOGY – The Doctrine of Salvation

The Means of Grace – Prayer

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 21.3–21.6 The Nature of Prayer: Prayer, with thanksgiving, is a special part of religious worship and is required by God of all men. It must be made in the name of the Son, by the help of the Spirit, according to God’s will, with understanding, reverence, humility, fervency, faith, love, and perseverance. For Whom We Pray: We may pray for ourselves and others, for the living and not for the dead, and not for those known to have sinned the sin unto death. The Rule and Example of Prayer: The rule for all prayer is the Word of God, but Christ gave us a perfect pattern in the Lord’s Prayer, teaching both the matter and manner of our prayers. The Goal of Prayer: Through prayer we express dependence, enjoy communion, and glorify God by acknowledging Him as our Father and King.	WSC 98–107 Q. 98 <i>What is prayer?</i> A. Prayer is an offering up of our desires to God, for things agreeable to His will, in the name of Christ, by the help of His Spirit, with confession of our sins and thankful acknowledgment of His mercies. Q. 99–107 <i>What rule has God given for our direction in prayer?</i> A. The whole Word of God directs us, but especially the Lord’s Prayer, which contains all the principles of prayer. Each petition—hallowing God’s name, seeking His kingdom, doing His will, daily bread, forgiveness, guidance, and praise—teaches the scope of a godly life.	WLC 178–196 Q. 178 <i>What is prayer?</i> A. Prayer is an offering up of our desires to God in the name of Christ, by the help of the Spirit, with confession and thanksgiving. Q. 185 <i>How are we to pray?</i> A. With reverence, awareness of God’s majesty, sincerity, submission, and confidence that He hears us for Christ’s sake. Q. 186–196 <i>How does the Lord’s Prayer instruct us?</i> A. It teaches us the order and content of prayer: to begin with God’s glory, to depend upon Him for all good, to seek forgiveness and strength against sin, and to end with praise to His sovereign majesty. Summary: Prayer is the soul’s conversation with God—rooted in faith, framed by Scripture, led by the Spirit, and aimed at God’s glory and our transformation.

ECCLESIOLOGY – The Doctrine of the Church

The Nature of the Church

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 25.1 – 25.6	WSC 62 – 63, 85–88	WLC 62 – 66, 108–110, 183
The Church Defined: The universal or catholic Church is the whole number of God’s elect who have been, are, or shall be gathered into one under Christ, its Head. It is the spouse, the body, and the fullness of Him who fills all in all. The Visible Church: Under the Gospel there is also a visible Church, which consists of all who profess the true religion and their children. It is the kingdom of the Lord Jesus Christ, the house and family of God, outside of which there is ordinarily no possibility of salvation. The Ministry of the Church: To this Church Christ has given the ministry, oracles, and ordinances of God for the gathering and perfecting of the saints in this life, and by His presence and Spirit they will continue until the end of the world. The Purity of the Church: Particular churches are more or less pure according to how clearly the Gospel is preached, the sacraments rightly administered, and discipline maintained. Christ	Q. 62 <i>What are the visible means of grace?</i> A. The Word, sacraments, and prayer, all instituted by Christ for the Church’s continual life and growth. Q. 63 <i>What is the visible Church?</i> A. The visible Church is the whole body of professing believers, together with their children, throughout the world. Q. 85 <i>What does God require of us that we may escape His wrath and curse due to us for sin?</i> A. Faith in Jesus Christ, repentance unto life, and diligent use of all the outward means whereby Christ communicates to us the benefits of redemption — that is, through participation in His Church.	Q. 62 <i>What is the visible Church?</i> A. The visible Church under the Gospel is a society made up of all who profess the true faith and their children. It is the kingdom of the Lord Jesus Christ and the house and family of God. Q. 63 <i>What special privilege has Christ given to His visible Church?</i> A. He has given the ministry of the Word and sacraments for the gathering and perfecting of the saints, and promises to be with them to the end of the age. Q. 64–66 <i>What is the invisible Church and how is it related to the visible?</i> A. The invisible Church consists of the whole number of the elect, past, present, and future. It is the spiritual reality of which the visible Church is the outward expression. Christ’s care extends to both; He gathers, preserves, and defends them against all enemies until the consummation of all things.

alone is the Lord and Judge of the Church, and even the purest on earth are subject to mixture and error. The Headship of Christ: There is no other head of the Church but the Lord Jesus Christ. The pope of Rome cannot in any sense be head of the Church, for Christ alone rules and defends His people and governs all things for their good.		Summary: The Church is both visible and invisible—one people under one Head, Jesus Christ. Through its ministry of Word, sacrament, and discipline, Christ builds His body and displays His glory in the world
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ECCLESIOLOGY – The Doctrine of the Church

The Communion of Saints

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 26.1–26.3 The Nature of Communion: All saints who are united to Jesus Christ, their Head, by His Spirit and by faith, share in Him in His graces, sufferings, death, resurrection, and glory. Being united to the same Savior, they are also united to one another in love, and have fellowship in each other’s gifts and graces. The Extent of Communion: This communion extends beyond local and temporal boundaries. It includes all believers in every age and nation — those now living, those who have died in the Lord, and those yet to be gathered. Together they form one spiritual body, the universal Church of Christ. The Exercise of Communion: Believers are called to maintain holy fellowship and mutual service — in worship, encouragement, and material support — as God gives opportunity. This communion expresses itself in the sharing of spiritual and temporal gifts, bearing one another’s burdens, and promoting each other’s good. The Limits of Communion: The communion of saints does not erase personal property, family duties, or lawful authority. Christians remain stewards of	WSC 86–88 Q. 86 <i>What is faith in Jesus Christ?</i> A. Faith in Jesus Christ is a saving grace, whereby we receive and rest upon Him alone for salvation, as He is offered to us in the Gospel. Q. 87 <i>What is repentance unto life?</i> A. Repentance unto life is a saving grace, whereby the sinner turns from sin unto God with full purpose of new obedience. Q. 88 <i>What are the outward and ordinary means whereby Christ communicates to us the benefits of redemption?</i> A. The Word, sacraments, and prayer — all of which are made effectual to the elect for salvation. <i>(These means are shared by all the</i>	WLC 65–66 Q. 65 <i>What special benefits do the members of the invisible Church enjoy through Christ?</i> A. They are united to one another in love, having communion in each other’s gifts and graces, and are bound to perform such duties toward each other as tend to their mutual good — both inwardly and outwardly. Q. 66 <i>What is that union which the elect have with Christ?</i> A. The union which the elect have with Christ is the work of God’s grace, whereby they are spiritually and mystically joined to Him as their Head and Husband. This union is real, vital, and indissoluble; from it flows all communion with Him and with one another in His body. Summary: The communion of saints is the living fellowship of all believers in union with Christ and with one another. It transcends geography and time, joining the Church militant on earth with the Church triumphant in heaven, until all are gathered in glory.

their own callings and possessions, yet use all for the welfare of the body of Christ. The Goal of Communion: In Christ, believers are made one household of faith, reflecting the unity and love of the Triune God, and anticipating the perfect communion of heaven.	<i>saints, expressing their unity in Christ across all ages.)</i>	
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ECCLESIOLOGY – The Doctrine of the Church

The Government and Discipline of the Church

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 30.1–30.4; 31.1–31.4 The Source of Church Authority: The Lord Jesus Christ, as King and Head of His Church, has appointed a government distinct from that of the civil magistrate. To Him all power in heaven and earth is given, and by His Word and Spirit He rules His Church for its edification and protection. The Purpose of Discipline: Christ has given officers authority to administer correction and restoration. Discipline is exercised to reclaim the erring, deter others from sin, purify the Church, vindicate Christ’s honor, and promote godly edification. It is an act of love, seeking the spiritual health of Christ’s body. The Manner of Discipline: The keys of the kingdom are entrusted to the officers of the Church. They declare the will of Christ, admit or exclude from the sacraments, and pronounce forgiveness or censure according to His Word. Excommunication is used only when necessary and always with the goal of repentance and reconciliation. The Courts of the Church: For the better government and unity of the Church, assemblies may be constituted at local, regional, and general levels (session,	WSC 49–52 Q. 49–52 <i>What does the second commandment require and forbid?</i> A. It requires receiving and keeping pure all God’s ordinances of worship and government, and forbids worshiping or governing the Church by human inventions or traditions. <i>(The Church’s government and discipline belong to Christ alone, whose rule maintains holiness and peace among His people.)</i>	WLC 108–110, 183 Q. 108 <i>What are the duties required in the second commandment?</i> A. Keeping pure and entire all ordinances God has appointed in His Word, including Church government and discipline. Q. 109 <i>What are the sins forbidden?</i> A. The corruption of God’s worship and the neglect or abuse of His ordinances, including Church discipline. Q. 183 <i>For whom are we to pray?</i> A. For the whole Church of Christ on earth, for its purity and peace, for faithful ministers, and for the restoration of those who have fallen. Summary: Church discipline is the compassionate exercise of Christ’s authority through His appointed officers to restore the wandering, guard the truth, and preserve the peace and purity of the Church. It mirrors God’s fatherly correction—firm, just, and restorative.

presbytery, synod, general assembly). These bodies exercise authority in matters ecclesiastical, always subject to the Word and Spirit of Christ.

The Spirit of Discipline: Church censures must be carried out with gentleness, impartiality, and humility, remembering that all authority is ministerial and declarative. Christ alone is Lord of the conscience and Judge of His people.

ECCLESIOLOGY – The Doctrine of the Church

The Civil Magistrate and the Church

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 23.1 – 23.4 God’s Ordination of Civil Authority: God, the supreme Lord and King of all the world, has ordained civil magistrates under Him to be for His glory and for the public good. For this purpose, He has armed them with the power of the sword for the defense and encouragement of those who do good and for the punishment of evildoers. The Duties of Magistrates: Civil rulers are to maintain justice and peace according to the righteous laws of God revealed in nature and in His Word. They must protect the person and good name of all citizens, preserve lawful liberties, and ensure that the outward peace and order of society are kept. The Duties of Christians toward Magistrates: It is the duty of Christians to make supplications and prayers for their rulers, to honor their persons, pay lawful dues and taxes, obey their lawful commands, and submit to their authority for conscience’ sake. Civil government is God’s servant for our good. The Relationship of Church and State: The civil magistrate may not assume the administration	WSC 105–107 Q. 105 <i>What do we pray for in the fifth petition, “Thy kingdom come”?</i> A. That Satan’s kingdom may be destroyed, the kingdom of grace advanced, ourselves and others brought into it and kept in it, and the kingdom of glory hastened. Q. 106 <i>What do we pray for in the sixth petition, “Thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven”?</i> A. That God, by His grace, would make us able and willing to know, obey, and submit to His will in all things, as the angels do in heaven. <i>(These petitions teach believers to live under God’s rule in every sphere, honoring lawful authority while seeking the triumph of Christ’s kingdom.)</i>	WLC 191 Q. 191 <i>What do we pray for in the second petition of the Lord’s Prayer?</i> A. We pray that the kingdom of sin and Satan may be destroyed, the gospel propagated throughout the world, the Jews called, the fullness of the Gentiles brought in, the Church furnished with faithful officers and maintained by civil peace, that the ordinances of Christ may be purely dispensed, and that the kingdom of glory may be hastened. Summary: God has ordained both the Church and the civil magistrate under His sovereign rule. The magistrate upholds outward order and justice; the Church proclaims grace and truth. When each honors its divine calling, both together serve the advance of Christ’s kingdom and the welfare of humanity.

of the Word, sacraments, or keys of the kingdom. Yet he ought to preserve an atmosphere of peace in which the Church may freely and purely exercise its calling. In all matters ecclesiastical, Christ alone is Head of the Church; in all matters civil, magistrates are subject to Him as Lord of lords and King of kings.

The End of Both Powers: The goal of both civil and ecclesiastical authority is the glory of God and the good of His people. When each remains within its God-appointed bounds, society flourishes and the gospel advances.

ESCHATOLOGY – The Doctrine of Last Things

The Intermediate State

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 32.1–32.3 The State of Men after Death: The bodies of men, after death, return to dust and see corruption; but their souls, which neither die nor sleep, having an immortal subsistence, immediately return to God who gave them. The Souls of the Righteous: The souls of the righteous, being made perfect in holiness, are received into the highest heavens, where they behold the face of God in light and glory, waiting for the full redemption of their bodies. The Souls of the Wicked: The souls of the wicked are cast into hell, where they remain in torments and utter darkness, reserved for the judgment of the great day. Besides these two places, Scripture acknowledges none. The Resurrection to Come: At the last day, those who are alive will not die but be changed, and all the dead shall be raised up with the same bodies, though transformed, and united again to their souls forever.	WSC 37 Q. 37 <i>What benefits do believers receive from Christ at death?</i> A. The souls of believers are at their death made perfect in holiness and do immediately pass into glory; and their bodies, still united to Christ, rest in their graves until the resurrection.	WLC 84–86 Q. 84 <i>What is the death of believers?</i> A. The death of believers is an end to sin and a passage into eternal life. They die in the Lord and rest from their labors. Q. 85 <i>What benefits do believers receive at death?</i> A. The souls of believers are at death made perfect in holiness and do immediately pass into glory; their bodies rest in their graves until the resurrection. Q. 86 <i>What is the communion in glory with Christ which the members of the invisible Church enjoy immediately after death?</i> A. The souls of believers are received into paradise, where they are with Christ and behold the glory of God, while waiting for the full redemption of their bodies. The souls of the wicked are cast into hell, where they remain in torment until the day of judgment. Summary: Death separates body and soul but cannot separate believers from Christ. The saints rest with the Lord in joy and holiness, awaiting the resurrection of the body and the final restoration of all things.

ESCHATOLOGY – The Doctrine of Last Things

The Final Judgment and the Life to Come

Westminster Confession of Faith	Westminster Shorter Catechism	Westminster Larger Catechism
WCF 33.1–33.3 The Day Appointed: God has appointed a day in which He will judge the world in righteousness by Jesus Christ, to whom all power and judgment are given by the Father. On that day, not only the fallen angels but all people who have lived upon the earth shall appear before His tribunal to give an account of their thoughts, words, and deeds, and to receive judgment according to what they have done in the body, whether good or evil. The Purpose of Judgment: God’s purpose is to manifest the glory of His mercy in the salvation of the elect and the glory of His justice in the condemnation of the reprobate. The righteous will go into everlasting life and receive the fullness of joy and refreshing from the presence of the Lord; the wicked, who do not know God and obey not the Gospel of Jesus Christ, will be cast into eternal torment and punished with everlasting destruction. The Certainty and Comfort of Judgment: God has fixed the day of judgment to deter men from sin and to comfort the godly in adversity. The	WSC 38 Q. 38 <i>What benefits do believers receive from Christ at the resurrection?</i> A. At the resurrection, believers, being raised up in glory, shall be openly acknowledged and acquitted in the day of judgment, and made perfectly blessed in the full enjoyment of God to all eternity.	WLC 87–90 Q. 87 <i>What is the communion in glory with Christ which the members of the invisible Church shall enjoy at the resurrection?</i> A. At the resurrection and final judgment, believers, being raised up in glory, shall be openly acknowledged and acquitted before the world, made perfectly blessed in full enjoyment of God forever. Q. 88 <i>What shall immediately follow the resurrection?</i> A. The general and final judgment of angels and men. Q. 89 <i>What shall be done to the wicked at the day of judgment?</i> A. They shall be set on Christ’s left hand and, upon clear evidence of their guilt, be cast into everlasting torments with the devil and his angels. Q. 90 <i>What shall be done to the righteous at the day of judgment?</i> A. The righteous shall be caught up with Christ, seated with Him in judgment, and welcomed into eternal life and glory.

knowledge that Christ will return to judge the living and the dead gives holy urgency to obedience and patient hope to the faithful.		Summary: At Christ's return, all shall rise and stand before His throne. The righteous will enter the joy of their Lord, the wicked everlasting punishment. The final judgment will fully reveal the wisdom, justice, and mercy of God, and usher in the eternal reign of Christ, in whom righteousness dwells forever.
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The End